



Craft endures: Mohammed Shami leads Bengal's charge as teammates celebrate their Ranji Trophy win over Uttarakhand at Eden Gardens, marking a triumphant homecoming for the pace spearhead. PTI

BETWEEN EDEN AND THE VALLEY

Across the Ranji map, **from Kolkata to Coimbatore to Kashmir**, our reporters find the game's heartbeat in the small moments that never make the highlights reel.

Mohammed Shami's fan following may not be as widespread as that of M. S. Dhoni, Virat Kohli or Rohit Sharma, but his 'Shamidom' has a steady presence across the country. Whether it's an away match or a home engagement, when Shami dons the whites for Bengal in the Ranji Trophy, fans throng the stadiums to cheer their beloved star. Shami, too, reciprocates their affection.

After leading Bengal to an eight-wicket win over Uttarakhand

with his seven-wicket haul in the Ranji Trophy season opener at Eden Gardens, Shami acknowledged his fans' support throughout the contest. He went up to them to sign autographs on sheets of paper, caps, jerseys, bats, balls, posters and even mobile phone covers — all with great patience.

In a short video, Shami declared, "I'm here to stay!" — a statement that should delight his followers.

Y.B. Sarangi

Cricket on the field, feasts off it

Patting its belly, the Diary declares

with pleasure that it was a gastronomically satisfying trip!

The caterer for the match was the popular Madhampatty Pakashala, thanks to the TNCA! Although there was no non-vegetarian food for the reporters (there were only two of us), our TNCA liaison used his influence to have some dishes smuggled in for us every day. Lip-smacking stuff, no complaints!

The day before the match, the Diary had an episode of Breakfast with Champions! Sai Kishore made an offer the Diary couldn't refuse: to have breakfast with him.